

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Information and Ideas	Central Ideas and Details	Medium

Question

The following text is from Ezra Pound’s 1909 poem “Hymn III,” based on the work of Marcantonio Flaminio.

As a fragile and lovely flower unfolds its gleaming
foliage on the breast of the fostering earth, if
the dew and the rain draw it forth;
So doth my tender mind flourish, if it be fed with the
sweet dew of the fostering spirit,
Lacking this, it beginneth straightway to languish,
even as a floweret born upon dry earth, if the
dew and the rain tend it not.

Based on the text, in what way is the human mind like a flower?

Answer

- A. It becomes increasingly vigorous with the passage of time.
- B. It draws strength from changes in the weather.
- C. It requires proper nourishment in order to thrive.
- D. It perseveres despite challenging circumstances.

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer because it presents a description of how the human mind is like a flower that is directly supported by the text. The text compares the needs of a “fragile and lovely flower” to those of the speaker’s “tender mind”: both need to be fed if they’re going to survive. Without such feeding, they’ll “beginneth straightway to languish,” or weaken. Thus, the text suggests that the human mind is like a flower in that they both need proper nourishment in order to thrive.

Choice A is incorrect because the text doesn’t address the passage of time or describe either the human mind or a flower as becoming increasingly vigorous. Choice B is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that human minds or flowers draw strength from changes in weather. The references to rain in the text pertain to a flower’s need for water rather than the general effects of changing weather. Choice D is incorrect because the text doesn’t suggest that the human mind or a flower will persist regardless of challenging circumstances. In fact, the text indicates that they’ll both languish right away if not given what they need.